

**Algorithmic Recommendation and Construction of Maternal Identity on
Xiaohongshu: Users' Interpretations and Experiences**

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1. Introduction

1.1 Research Background

Social media platforms have become crucial spaces where individuals seek information and connect with others. In China, Xiaohongshu has gained notable influence as a lifestyle-oriented platform where users share personal experiences, practical advice, and highly curated portrayals of daily life (Ngu, 2025). Xiaohongshu is heavily shaped by recommendation feeds, where users are constantly exposed to content based on their browsing, searching, and engagement behaviours (Liu, 2024).

This study focuses on users' experiences on Xiaohongshu during the transition from career to motherhood. This identity shift is important, as women need to adjust to new responsibilities, social expectations, and emotional changes while also negotiating other aspects of their identity (Hwang, Choi, and An, 2022). Previous research suggests that the transition to motherhood can begin before childbirth and may reshape how women understand their social roles and identities (Hebl et al., 2007). Similarly, social media platforms may also shape and reflect new mothers' digital identities.

Many studies on digital identity focus primarily on self-presentation, in which users actively choose how to present themselves online (Bullingham and Vasconcelos, 2013). While this perspective is useful, it may not fully explain how identity is shaped in recommendation-driven platforms. In this study, digital identity is understood as something reflected through algorithmically recommended content, classification, and repeated exposure.

The concept of "motherhood online" is useful for understanding this research field.

Mackenzie and Zhao (2021) refer to the term as the opportunities or difficulties mothers may face through the content produced by maternal identities or related to the motherhood

community in digital environments. Existing research has shown that mothers may face high standards of social expectations in offline settings (O'Reilly, 2010). However, the digital space may also reproduce idealised images of motherhood, foster comparisons, and reinforce social expectations about what a “good mother” should be.

Therefore, this study focuses on new mothers’ experiences on Xiaohongshu to understand how they interpret changes in recommended content during the transition from career roles to motherhood. As their interests, roles, and emotional needs may shift during this period, the content they repeatedly encounter on the platform may reflect their changing priorities and emerging maternal identity. Bucher’s (2016) concept of the “algorithmic imaginary” helps explain how users develop their own understandings of algorithmic recommendations through everyday platform use, including participants’ explanations of why motherhood-related content starts to dominate feeds. Therefore, this study uses qualitative interviews with new mothers to focus on their lived experiences and interpretations, rather than on the technical operation of Xiaohongshu’s algorithm.

1.2 Research Aim

This research investigates how women during identity transition from career to motherhood interpret algorithmically recommended content on Xiaohongshu and how this relates to their digital identity and online experiences regarding a sense of belonging and exclusion.

1.2.1 Main Research Question:

How do new mothers interpret algorithmically recommended content on Xiaohongshu as reflecting their digital identity, and how does this relate to their online experiences?

1.2.2 Sub-Questions:

1. How do participants interpret the relationship between their browsing behaviour, the content recommended to them, and digital identity?
2. How does repeated exposure to maternal content on Xiaohongshu generate their feelings of belonging and exclusion?
3. How do participants experience career-motherhood identity tensions within algorithmically curated content, and how do they respond to these tensions?

This study is significant because it contributes to the limited research examining algorithmic recommendations from a user-centred, identity-focused perspective. While existing studies have discussed platform algorithms, digital motherhood, and online identity separately, less attention has been paid to how new mothers interpret recommended content as part of their identity transition. By focusing on Xiaohongshu, this research explores how algorithmically curated content may shape maternal identity, belonging, and exclusion within a Chinese social media context.

The study also extends existing discussions of digital identity by moving beyond self-presentation. It shows that users' digital identity is not only shaped by what they choose to present online, but also by how they are positioned by recommendation systems and the content repeatedly shown to them. Therefore, the study understands digital identity as platform-positioning during the transition to motherhood.

1.3 Structure Overview

This dissertation is structured into five chapters. Chapter 1 presents the research background, identifies the research gap, states the research aim, questions, and highlights the significance

of the study. Chapter 2 reviews relevant literature on digital identity, algorithmic recommendation, motherhood transition, and feelings of belonging and exclusion in digital environments. It establishes the theoretical framework for understanding how algorithmically suggested content on Xiaohongshu might influence new mothers' perceptions of digital identities, belonging, and exclusion. Chapter 3 details the methodology, including the qualitative research design, rationale of the platform and participant selection, data collection methods, data analysis, limitations, and ethical considerations. Chapter 4 presents an analysis of interview findings organised around three main themes: (1) Identity Transition and Perceptions of Algorithmic Recommendation, (2) Belonging and Exclusion, and (3) Identity Negotiation and Adaptation. Chapter 5 concludes the dissertation by summarising the key findings, reflecting on the research contributions, and proposing directions for future research.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Introduction

This literature review discusses the key theories and debates that are related to the research topic. It is structured around four main themes: (1) Digital Identity, (2) Platform Algorithmic Recommendation, (3) From Career to Motherhood, and (4) Belonging and Exclusion in Online Environments. Together, these themes establish the theoretical framework for analysing how women interpret and experience algorithmically recommended content during the identity transition from career to motherhood.

The review begins by outlining how identity is understood as a social and relational process in 2.2. It then extends this discussion to digital identity, highlighting how existing research has mainly focused on self-presentation, while paying less attention to how platform structures may reflect and shape identity through visibility. 2.3 examines how algorithmic

recommendation systems organise content and structure what users repeatedly see online, with a focus on datafication, classification, algorithmic visibility, and users' "algorithmic imaginary". Building on the theoretical foundation of digital identity and algorithmic structures, 2.4 reviews and identifies a research gap in existing work on work-family conflict during early motherhood, which tends to focus less on how this conflict and identity negotiation may be experienced through digital platforms. Finally, 2.5 explores how algorithmic visibility may create experiences of belonging and exclusion in digital environments, potentially reinforcing certain identities while marginalising others.

2.2 Digital Identity

2.2.1 Identity

In sociology and cultural studies, identity is often understood as a socially constructed and relational concept. Identity matters because it helps people understand who they are and how they are perceived by others, which in turn influences self-perception and social interaction (Burke and Stets, 2009). Jenkins (1996) defined identity as an ongoing process that changes through interaction with society and individuals, emphasising that individuals are labelled or categorised through both internal self-understanding and external social recognition. He argues that identity is not a fixed form; instead, it can be shaped and evolved through changing social roles. This perspective on identity provides the foundation for understanding the nature and the importance of identity transition in this research.

To better understand how this social interaction operates, Erving Goffman's metaphorical theory of performance identity provides an influential perspective. He describes identity as a theatrical performance in front of others in everyday social interactions (Goffman, 1959). By distinguishing between "back-stage" and "front-stage" behaviours, he suggests that how individuals manage their impressions depends on context and audience. To clarify,

Goffman's theory is often read as a single, authentic self behind these performances, but rather highlights how identity is produced through situational interaction and social expectations. This focus has since been developed in studies of digital and platformed environments, regarding the differences between “online” and “offline” behaviours, where identities may differ between virtual spaces and reality.

However, Goffman's theory is built on the idea that individuals have the most control over their performance, as individuals can choose what to show to and what to hide from others. Some scholars suggest that this idea becomes more complicated in the digital age. For example, Marwick and Boyd (2011) argue that the boundaries between “front-stage” and “back-stage” are often blurred in online spaces, as our personal and social lives mix on the same platform. More importantly, they emphasise that the “stage” itself – the social media platform – is not a neutral space, as identity in digital environments is enacted not only by individuals but also structured by platform mechanisms. This will be further explained in Section 2.3, Algorithmic Recommendation Content.

2.2.2 Digital Identity

Within digital contexts, the understanding of identity has been extended into research in the social media domain, often exploring how individuals actively construct themselves on platforms such as TikTok or Instagram, through carefully choosing their profile pictures, posts, or other curated personal information (Buss, Le and Haimson, 2021). These practices reflect a conscious, strategic form of self-presentation to imagined audiences. Some scholars also refer to this digital identity as “online identity” or the “online self” (Bullingham and Vasconcelos, 2013; Kim, Zheng, and Gupta, 2011). Much of this literature often investigates how individuals manage online visibility and authenticity, especially the (mis)alignment between the online “self” and offline “self”. As such, digital identity has frequently been

conceptualised as an extension of self-presentation practices into mediated spaces, effectively extending Goffman's performative identity framework from face-to-face interaction into the digital age.

However, this dominant paradigm, with an emphasis on active self-presentation, captures only one form of digital identity formation, presupposing the user as the primary author while neglecting the role of the platforms that organise content in digital spaces. It is important to note that not all users actively create content on social media platforms, yet they still participate in digital environments and are positioned within them. As social media platforms increasingly rely on algorithmic systems to organise visibility and content exposure, online identities may be shaped not only by users' actions but also by external systems and structures (Gillespie, 2014, pp.167-193). Thus, this user-centred understanding of digital identity may be insufficient to capture how identity is experienced.

Therefore, this research shifts the focus to a more passive approach to digital identity formation, emphasising the role of platform structures rather than user control over online identity construction. The recommendation feed can be understood as a form of feedback mechanism, through which users are repeatedly exposed to the type of content that reflects how the platform categorises them. As Bucher (2018) argues, algorithmic systems do not simply organise information but actively shape how users are positioned and understood by the platform. This suggests that users may recognise themselves through what they view on the platform, as if the platform acts as a mirror that presents a particular version of who they are. As Couldry (2012) indicates, users are not the only agency in shaping their identity; platforms also have agency. Therefore, in this study, digital identity is understood not as self-presentation, but as something ongoing, reflected by the platform through processes of visibility, categorisation, and in how users understand themselves through these processes.

To grasp this definition of digital identity, it is crucial to understand how platforms' algorithmic recommendation systems work.

2.3 Algorithmic Recommendation Content

2.3.1 Algorithms and Visibility

Gillespie (2010) analyses the structural logic of social media platforms, demonstrating that platforms are not neutral online spaces but active shapers of social experience. Platforms operate according to specific algorithmic processes embedded in everyday online activities, including “friending, liking, sharing, rating, and recommending” (Van Dijck, Poell and De Waal, 2018, p. 33), as well as searching, scrolling, and the time users spend viewing content. For commercial reasons, platforms aim to keep users engaged as long as possible on a specific platform (Narayanan, 2023). To achieve this, algorithms are used to study and predict users’ interests and preferences based on behavioural data. Once the platform captures users’ behavioural patterns, the algorithm systems will optimise content visibility by prioritising certain types of posts while excluding others. This process effectively shapes what users see and do not see in their feeds (Gillespie, 2014, pp. 167-193), suggesting that visibility is not simply about what is available to see, but about what is selectively made to appear through algorithmic processes.

Research on Xiaohongshu further illustrates this process. As a recommendation-driven platform centred around ongoing personalised content feeds, Xiaohongshu continuously present users with personalised content based on their interactions (Zhang, Chen and Xi, 2020). Users on Xiaohongshu are exposed to specific content categories even when they do not actively search for them, leading certain topics to become more dominant in the feed over time. This means that visibility on Xiaohongshu depends not only on users’ intentional content searches but also on their entire online activity.

2.3.2 Datafication, Classification, and the Datafied Self

While algorithmic systems determine what users see, they also decide what categories users are assigned to through classification. Through online practices such as tagging, recommendations, and classification, platforms assign users to particular interest groups or identity categories (Cheney-Lippold, 2011), which, in turn, influence the communities they are exposed to and the content they repeatedly engage with. As Cheney-Lippold (2011) noted, users can be termed “datafied selves,” in which their data is continuously extracted, analysed, and perhaps repurposed. This datafication process captures users’ ongoing and evolving behaviours and feeds these data patterns back to users through algorithmically recommended content.

Even though users do not actively post or manage their online presence, their browsing behaviour is quietly recorded and categorised, thereby shaping their digital identities. Therefore, rather than understanding digital identity as being constructed solely through users’ self-presentation, it can be shaped through algorithmic feedback mechanisms that reflect patterns of behaviour back to users (Vombatkere et al., 2024). This supports the definition of digital identity in this research, as outlined earlier, which is represented by the recommendation feed that adapts to users’ ongoing needs and behaviour.

Content recommendation can both reflect and shape users’ interests. As users continue to interact with specific types of content or opinions on social media, the algorithm further reinforces users’ interests. Over time, this may lead to an “echo chamber”. This term in social media studies refers to situations in which users are exposed to information that reinforces their existing interests or beliefs, while other information is less visible (Quattrociocchi, Scala, and Sunstein, 2016). However, these mechanisms are often not fully transparent to users. Studies have shown that many users are unaware of how algorithms rank or hide

content, and how algorithms perceive and categorise them (Eslami et al., 2015; Rader and Gray, 2015). Therefore, it is crucial to examine how users interpret the connection between their browsing behaviour, the recommended content, and their digital identities.

2.3.3 Users' Algorithmic Experience

The concept of the “algorithmic imaginary” proposed by Bucher (2016) has important implications for social media studies, as this theory shifts attention to the user perspective and to the understanding of platforms for the first time. Bucher describes the “algorithmic imaginary” as the beliefs and expectations users have about algorithms, including what they are and how they function. Importantly, these understandings are based on everyday experience rather than professional technical knowledge. As this theory has been further developed by scholars, similar ideas are also discussed under the term “folk theories”, which also refer to users' incomplete assumptions of algorithmic systems (Eslami et al., 2016; DeVito, Gergle and Birnholtz, 2017). These everyday understandings of algorithms shape how users interpret the content repeatedly presented to them, which has important implications for their experience on social media platforms.

Overall, the theoretical discussion above outlines how digital identity can be understood in relation to platform environments, particularly through processes of algorithmic visibility, classification, and user interpretation. These processes may have a pronounced effect on people experiencing an identity transition, as their interests, roles, and priorities are shifting (Roccas and Brewer, 2002). Thus, this study considers the transition to motherhood as the research site, focusing on early motherhood as a phase when identity may be redefined and renegotiated (Simon and Landis, 1989). The following section reviews existing research on the motherhood transition to understand why this process is significant and how it may be experienced within algorithmically curated social media environments.

2.4 From Career to Motherhood

2.4.1 Motherhood Transition

An individual usually experiences various significant events, one of which is identity transition, a process of significant changes in social roles that reshape how individuals understand themselves (Ashforth, 2000). Such transitions may include moving from single to married or divorced status, transitioning to first-time motherhood, or returning to work after maternity leave. These transitions can be either adding or losing roles, requiring individuals to adjust their sense of self accordingly. Research shows that although transition to motherhood itself is something women are often looking forward to, it often brings emotional changes such as anxiety, uncertainty, and even depression (Hwang, Choi and An, 2022). As Miller (2007) indicates, motherhood transition should not be understood merely as a change in social roles, but as a process of emotional reorganisation.

Scholars in social identity research argue that identities provide individuals with a sense of stability, meaning, and belonging in everyday life (Haslam et al., 2009). When a person experiences a transition that alters their social roles, this stability may be disrupted, requiring the individual to reconstruct how they understand themselves. Importantly, individuals often hold multiple identities simultaneously, and these identities may not always align with one another (Roccas and Brewer, 2002). As Ladge, Clair and Greenberg (2012) indicate, motherhood transition can involve not only adopting a new role but also negotiating tensions between existing and emerging identities, such as between maintaining their professional competence and meeting expectations of being a “good mother”, as well as challenges in balancing limited time and physical resources across these roles.

2.4.2 From Career to Motherhood

In recent decades, social expectations of women have gradually shifted from being primarily responsible for domestic work and childcare to a dual identity, in which they are expected to excel in both career and family roles (Simon and Landis, 1989). The society also expects “intensive mothering,” encouraging women to believe that childcare demands constant attention and professional advice, and that mothers should prioritise it over their careers (O'Reilly, 2010). This reflects that being a mother does not simply add another role to women’s lives; rather, it reshapes how women are evaluated in both public and private environments. As a result, this expectation has made the transition from career woman to motherhood a particularly complex identity shift. Importantly, this transition does not begin only after childbirth, but often starts during pregnancy, when women begin to adjust their identities and expectations (Hebl et al., 2007).

Existing research on the transition from career to motherhood often focuses on the challenges pregnant women and early mothers face from work, which pays attention to the pressure and welfare that early mothers have from work, including risks of job insecurity, reduced income, limited maternity leave, or slowed career progression after childbirth (Russell et al., 2011; McIntosh et al., 2012). Such studies highlight how structural and organisational factors shape women’s wellbeing during early motherhood. Some also focus on the balance or conflict between work and family responsibilities, as they face dual pressure from both domains (Okorn et al., 2025). For example, returning to work after maternity leave can be a particularly stressful transition, as women are expected to resume professional roles while still providing most of their time to their children to meet the expectations of the “good mother” template (Ladge and Greenberg, 2015). This situation is not only about managing responsibilities but also about negotiating between different identity expectations as

individuals attempt to reconcile their roles as professionals and mothers. This may result in both physical exhaustion and emotional strain, particularly when expectations across different roles conflict (Roccas and Brewer, 2002).

However, much of this literature focuses on offline scenarios, while paying less attention to how emotions change and to identity negotiation that may also occur in digital environments. Therefore, it is important to examine how platforms' algorithms shape new mothers' experiences in digital environments, particularly how they position themselves in relation to others. This leads to a focus on how social media platforms may influence their sense of belonging and exclusion in motherhood or professional roles, which will be discussed in the following section.

2.5 Belonging and Exclusion in Algorithmic Environments

2.5.1 The Importance of Belonging

The concept of belonging has been widely discussed in social and cultural studies. Belonging is a state in which individuals feel recognised, understood, and secure within a group (Hoffmann and Ignatieff, 1994), which can provide emotional security and a sense of acceptance (Correll and Park, 2005). Baumeister and Leary (1995) propose that the need to belong is a fundamental human motivation, in which individuals seek to maintain meaningful social connections. The need to belong may become particularly significant during periods of identity transition, such as the transition to motherhood. At this stage, individuals often experience uncertainty and emotional vulnerability as they adjust to new roles and responsibilities (Hebl et al., 2007). For new mothers, belonging is not only about social connection but also about feeling understood, supported, and less isolated as they navigate unfamiliar experiences (Seppälä et al., 2021).

In addition, belonging is closely connected to identity formation. Tajfel and Turner's (1986) social identity theory suggests that individuals understand who they are, in part, through their membership in social groups. Similarly, Jenkins (1996) emphasises that identity develops through processes of internal self-definition and external recognition. In this sense, belonging is not only an emotional experience but also a process through which individuals position themselves within a social context. However, in digital environments, belonging does not rely solely on direct interaction with others. Instead, it may be shaped through content exposure. On recommendation-driven platforms, individuals may come to feel a sense of belonging through recommended content in their feeds, which signals the kinds of identities they are and the content they value (Vombatkere et al., 2024).

Beyond recognition, belonging also involves boundary construction. Yuval-Davis (2006) argues that belonging is shaped by social and symbolic processes that define who is considered "inside" or "outside" a community. These boundaries shape experiences of inclusion and exclusion, as they determine which identities are validated and which may be marginalised. In platform environments, such boundaries may be produced through algorithmic classification and repeated recommendation. Previous studies have shown that algorithmic systems play a key role in organising visibility and personalising content (Bucher, 2018; Cheney-Lippold, 2011), thereby influencing how users are grouped and represented within digital spaces. Similarly, in digital motherhood spaces, certain representations of motherhood may become dominant, while others may be less visible or marginalised (Astudillo-Mendoza and Cifuentes-Zunino, 2022). Thus, in addition to focusing only on which characteristics are prioritised, understanding how reduced visibility or marginalisation on platforms can lead to feelings of exclusion during the motherhood transition is also crucial.

2.5.2 Exclusion and Consequences

If belonging is linked to recognition and visibility, exclusion can be understood as the experience of being unseen, marginalised, or symbolically absent (Williams, 2007). Social and psychological studies have shown that experiencing exclusion can lead to negative consequences, such as lower self-esteem (Twenge et al., 2007). Even subtle experiences of exclusion can cause emotional distress or feelings of rejection (Williams and Nida, 2016).

Exclusion does not necessarily require direct rejection. In digital environments, exclusion may be experienced through reduced visibility rather than explicit removal (Schneider et al., 2017). Tajfel and Turner (1986) point out that group membership contributes to self-concept; when one's perceived group affiliation is weakened, identity stability may be affected. Roccas and Brewer (2002) further argue that tensions between multiple identities can cause psychological strain, particularly when one identity becomes less recognised in a given context. Therefore, in digital environments, if one identity becomes relatively less visible, individuals may experience reduced confidence in that identity or increased self-doubt (Verkuyten and Thijs, 2006).

In addition to reduced visibility, exclusion may also be experienced through comparisons and feelings of inferiority with others within the same community. Festinger (1954) suggests that everyday interaction offers opportunities for self-evaluation between an individual and others. This comparative information is intensified on social media platforms by repeatedly exposing users to content that is more similar to what they value most (Joinson, 2008). Research shows that users tend to present a more positive side of themselves, which is very different from what is observed in offline interactions (Nadkarni and Hofmann, 2012), as in-person interaction may reveal more aspects of personal traits than the idealised self.

Therefore, this online self-presentation often provides users with biased information to compare (Fardouly et al., 2015).

Research has shown that many Chinese mothers enjoy sharing “mommy blogs” that showcase their parenting methods and their children, whom they are proud of; however, these representations are often selective and may present an idealised version of their everyday experiences. (Sun Sun Lim and Wang, 2024). These curated maternal portrayals on social media gain more visibility and engagement than ordinary, unfiltered everyday depictions (Wegener, Jage-D’Aprile and Plumeier, 2022), which may trigger upward social comparison. When viewing these idealised selves presented online, individuals may internalise them as expected lifestyle or role templates, serving as a standard for self-assessment (Vogel et al., 2014). As a result, these comparisons and feelings of inferiority may lead individuals to question their sense of belonging to a particular community or identity, thereby contributing to experiences of exclusion (Basu et al., 2023).

Therefore, the online environment goes beyond information delivery, influencing users’ self-perception and emotional experiences. This algorithmically shaped comparison may become more visible during periods of identity transition, when individuals are more sensitive to social cues and normative expectations.

3. Methodology

3.1 Introduction

This section outlines the methodology approach used in this study to investigate how new mothers interpret and make sense of algorithmically recommended content on Xiaohongshu, particularly in relation to their experiences of belonging, exclusion, and identity during early motherhood.

It first explains the interpretivist research design and the rationale for using qualitative interviews. It then discusses platform, participant, and sampling selection. Following this, the procedures for data collection and analysis are outlined, with particular attention to how themes were developed in relation to the research questions. Finally, this chapter addresses the study's limitations and ethical considerations.

3.2 Research Method and Design

This study adopted a qualitative, interpretivist approach to explore participants' interpretations and experiences of algorithmic recommendations on Xiaohongshu. From an interpretivist perspective, reality is understood through individuals' meanings and lived experiences (Nelson, Potrac and Groom, 2014). In this study, participants' accounts of how recommendations are treated as meaningful interpretations, rather than objective evidence of algorithmic mechanisms. Semi-structured interviews were chosen as the primary method because the research focuses on how participants understand, interpret, and emotionally respond to recommendation systems, which cannot be captured through structured surveys (Creswell, 2014; Qu and Dumay, 2011).

The interviews were conducted online due to geographic constraints, as the researcher was based in the UK while the participants were in China. Online interviews can reduce travel costs and offer greater flexibility in scheduling interview times across different locations (Bauman, 2015). Moreover, online voice-based interviews may reduce access to non-verbal cues (Varma et al., 2021). To address this, the researcher adopted a more flexible, interactive approach, using follow-up questions to encourage participants to elaborate on their responses and reviewing key excerpts against audio recordings during transcription. Reflexive notes were also recorded after each interview to capture impressions, potential biases, and emerging patterns. Also, an online voice-based format may create a more private, less visible

environment, allowing participants to feel more comfortable discussing sensitive topics related to motherhood and personal experiences (Sipes, Roberts, and Mullan, 2019).

In addition, this methodological choice addressed a gap in the existing literature. Many previous studies examining Xiaohongshu's algorithms focus on analysing platform data, such as large-scale social media datasets or computational analyses of content visibility, to understand how algorithmic systems operate (Wu, 2021; Zhang, Chen and Xi, 2020). While these approaches help explain the structural mechanisms of algorithms, they pay less attention to how users themselves interpret and experience these systems in everyday platform use. Therefore, this study used interviews to explore users' subjective interpretations of algorithmic recommendations and how these perceptions relate to online identity and belonging. From an interpretivist perspective, participants' accounts are treated as interpretations of their own platform experiences, which may be shaped by their personal backgrounds, beliefs, and lived experiences (Nelson, Potrac, and Groom, 2014).

3.3 Platform and Sampling Selection

This study selects Xiaohongshu as the case study platform due to its recommendation-driven content structure and strong focus on lifestyle representation (Ngu, 2025). Unlike purely informational platforms, Xiaohongshu is characterised by its combination of experience-sharing posts and a "recommendation feed" structure, in which users are continuously exposed to content related to consumption, self-improvement, and everyday practices. This includes motherhood-related content such as "good mother" practices, refined parenting styles, and postnatal body recovery templates (Liu and Wang, 2022). Therefore, Xiaohongshu is particularly suitable for this study, as its platform structure allows the researcher to examine how repeated exposure to normative content may shape users' interpretations of identity, belonging, and exclusion during motherhood transition.

Participants were recruited through Xiaohongshu, and interviews were conducted via WeChat. A recruitment post was published on Xiaohongshu outlining the aim and participation requirements, and interested individuals contacted the researcher voluntarily.

Participants need to meet the following criteria:

1. Women who are active Xiaohongshu users for at least three years.
2. Women who have become mothers within the past three years.
3. Participants must be over 18 years old.

These criteria were designed to ensure that participants have sufficient experience using the platform. Focusing on women who have become mothers within the past three years helps ensure participants can provide rich, recent accounts of their experiences, which is important for capturing more accurate and detailed reflections on identity change and platform use. To ensure participants met the study criteria, a brief screening was conducted before the interview (see Appendix D).

This recruitment strategy may introduce self-selection bias, as participants who volunteer are more likely to be active users and more willing to share their experiences. This may influence the findings, particularly regarding experiences of belonging or exclusion.

Regarding data protection, participants' personal information (such as WeChat contact details) was stored separately from interview transcripts. All identifying information was anonymised during transcription.

3.4 Data Collection

Seven participants were recruited, with in-depth interviews lasting approximately 30-40 minutes. Semi-structured interviews were used because they allow the researcher to adjust follow-up questions based on participants' responses (Adams, 2015), encouraging more meaningful feedback that aligns with interpretive accounts. Before the interview began, participants signed consent forms (see Appendix A and B), were informed of the research's purpose, and their right to withdraw at any time. With participants' permission, interviews were recorded and automatically transcribed in Apple Notes to support the analysis process.

Interview questions were guided by a topic framework covering four areas:

1. Platform use history (warm-up)
2. Understanding of recommendation systems (RQ1)
3. Experiences of belonging, support, and pressure (RQ2)
4. Career-motherhood tensions and coping strategies (RQ3)

Questions were designed with a questioning strategy to avoid leading participants, beginning with descriptive prompts (RQ1: "How do you understand the content recommended to you?"), which is consistent with studies of "algorithmic imaginaries" that focus on users' understandings of algorithms. This was followed by experience-focused questions (RQ2: "Have there been moments when it made you feel supported or, on the contrary, under pressure?). A dual approach was used by asking participants about both positive (support, belonging) and negative (pressure, exclusion) experiences. Finally, the interview focused on career-motherhood tension questions (RQ3: "Do you feel that your career identity becomes less visible on the platform?" and "How do you respond when the content does not match how you see yourself?"). These focus on whether participants felt their career identity was less visible or overshadowed by motherhood-related content on the platform, and how they

responded to this (e.g. ignoring content, selecting “not interested”, or using alternative accounts).

3.5 Data Analysis

Data were analysed using reflective thematic analysis (Braun and Clarke, 2006). This analysis adopts a hybrid coding approach that combines deductive and inductive strategies. Initial coding was guided by the research questions, while allowing new themes to emerge from the data.

The researcher first familiarised themselves with the data through repeated reading of transcripts. Meaningful segments were then coded, including both expected themes and unexpected or contradictory responses. This approach ensured that the analysis was not limited to confirming predefined assumptions. Codes were then grouped into broader themes representing patterns in participants’ interpretations and experiences. Themes were refined and defined to capture meaning-making patterns.

As the interviews were conducted in Chinese, only selected quotes were translated into English for presentation in this research. To ensure accuracy, the researcher carefully translated the data to preserve the original meaning of participants’ responses and avoid misinterpretation.

3.6 Limitation

One limitation of this study is its geographic scope, as participants were recruited from different cities across China, which may introduce variations in city tier, access to childcare resources, and employment structures. While this diversity allows the study to capture a wider range of experiences, it may also reduce comparability within a small sample (Bryman and Bell, 2015). As this research does not aim to examine regional differences, the findings

should be understood as reflecting individual experiences rather than representing specific geographic contexts.

Another limitation concerns the interview method. As interviews rely on participants' self-reported experiences and feelings, the responses may be influenced by personal perceptions or past memories (Dockrell, 2004). These factors may introduce potential bias in participants' accounts. However, since this research aims to explore how individuals interpret and experience algorithmic content, these subjective accounts remain valuable for understanding users' perceptions of algorithms and their sense of belonging in online environments.

3.7 Ethical Considerations

Ethical approval was obtained through King's College London's Research Ethics Minimal Risk Registration process. Participation in this study was voluntary, and participants were informed that they could stop the interview at any time. Their personal information was anonymised, and all recordings and transcripts will be securely stored and deleted after the dissertation has been marked.

3.8 Conclusion

Overall, the methodological choices adopted in this study are designed to support an interpretivist exploration of how participants make sense of algorithmically recommended content in their everyday platform use. In particular, the use of semi-structured interviews enables the study to capture participants' "algorithmic imaginaries", while the focus on lived experiences allows for a deeper understanding of how repeated exposure to platform content is associated with feelings of belonging, pressure, and exclusion. These methodological decisions provide the foundation for the following analysis chapter, which examines how participants interpret and respond to recommendation systems during the transition to

motherhood. Supplementary materials, including all data collection forms, participants' basic information, initial coding, and recruitment posts, are provided in the Appendix.

4. Discussion

This section organises interview responses into three main themes that align with the research questions and theoretical frameworks, while remaining grounded in the data. The themes are (1) Identity Transition and Perceptions of Algorithmic Recommendation, (2) Belonging and Exclusion, and (3) Identity Negotiation and Adaptation.

4.1 Identity Transition and Perceptions of Algorithmic Recommendation

(RQ1: How do participants interpret the relationship between their browsing behaviour, the content recommended to them, and digital identity?)

4.1.1 Changing Content and Identity

Most participants noticed that the content on Xiaohongshu had become heavily motherhood- or childcare-related since they were pregnant. Several participants described how their previous interests, such as fashion or beauty, gradually gave way to content related to early education, baby food, or childcare advice.

One mother described the shift as follows:

“I noticed I mainly look at content about mothers who just gave birth on Xiaohongshu during my pregnancy... because at that time, when you are pregnant, you feel both a strong sense of anticipation and a sense of uncertainty about what is going to happen in the future... One way to reduce that anxiety and fear is by browsing Xiaohongshu and learning from other mothers’ experiences.”

Her experience suggests that during pregnancy, there is a need for emotional and informational assurance. Her attention orientation to pregnancy content can be understood as an early indicator of an identity transition (Zhang et al., 2022), in which attention becomes increasingly oriented towards motherhood-related concerns.

One participant noted that she no longer actively searched for fashion content like she used to, but instead only passively views the posts from vloggers she had followed before, while actively searching for baby-related products. The shift in content she actively searches for reflects a reduced focus on her previous dominant identity and an increased interest towards her emerging identity as a mother. This reflects existing research suggesting that the emergence of a new identity can lead to the weakening or marginalisation of other identities, particularly during major life transitions (Stryker and Burke, 2000). This identity reorientation is amplified by Xiaohongshu's algorithmic mechanism, which gradually reshapes users' feeds through repeated exposure and content visibility (Zhang, Chen and Xi, 2020), aligning them with their prioritised maternal identity. However, participants hold their own understandings of why their feed content changes over time.

4.1.2 “Folk Theories” of Algorithms

When participants were asked to explain this content-changing process, their answers could be categorised into three types.

1. Behaviour-driven imaginary

Most believed recommendations on Xiaoshonghu are based on what they normally watch, click, and search for.

2. Engagement-based imaginary

A smaller group noted that the content in feeds is driven by their engagement with the same types of posts, including likes, saved posts, and video completion rates.

3. Data-driven imaginary

Participants simplified the mechanism as large-scale data collection, holding that the platform aggregates overall user behavioural data to automatically tailor recommended content.

Although these understandings were not technically precise, they still offer simplified and meaningful explanations of how their behaviours shape what they see. This finding aligns with Bucher's (2018) concept of "algorithmic imaginary", which suggests that users develop incomplete and informal assumptions of how algorithms operate. Based on their answers, it indicated that participants perceive a direct relationship between their browsing behaviour and content recommendations, even if this relationship is simplified or only partially understood. Their incomplete understandings can be explained by the opacity of algorithmic systems, where the underlying mechanisms remain largely untransparent to users (Ytre-Arne and Moe, 2021). However, this gap is important because it shapes how users understand their own role in producing their digital environments and may influence how they experience and respond to algorithmically curated content during identity transitions.

4.2 Belonging and Exclusion

(RQ2: How does repeated exposure to maternal content on Xiaohongshu generate their feelings of belonging and exclusion?)

As participants' recommended posts increasingly focused on childcare, they did not simply consume motherhood content but also developed two distinct yet interconnected types of

emotional responses: belonging through support and exclusion through comparison and stigma.

4.2.1 Belonging – Information and Emotional Support

When participants were asked how they felt a sense of belonging to motherhood through Xiaohongshu, all of them described this feeling as stemming from the content itself, primarily through repeated exposure. This indicates that belonging in this context is not only interaction-based but also content-driven, as evidenced by the repeated presence of relevant and recognisable content in the recommendation feed.

Participants often felt a sense of connection from the repeated presence of relevant and helpful information, such as content on child illness, breastfeeding, baby food, and parenting advice. This information can provide them with practical guidance to help them navigate unfamiliar aspects of motherhood, reducing uncertainty during this transition.

One participant shared an interesting perspective on how she felt supported by Xiaohongshu's recommended content. She said,

“Raising a child is like writing a dissertation. For me, the parenting content on Xiaohongshu is basically the literature review. You first identify what problems your child has, then think about how to solve them, how to put things into practice, and afterwards, you reflect on what worked and what did not. It's like constantly reviewing and revising.”

This quote shows that Xiaohongshu was not only seen as a source of information but also as an ongoing support system that helped participants make sense of motherhood. In this way, Xiaohongshu served as a space where motherhood became more manageable and understandable, helping reduce the uncertainty of the motherhood transition.

Other than useful information, Xiaohongshu also provide emotional support. One mother shared an example of how she felt understood on Xiaohongshu but found it hard to express in offline settings:

“My sexual relationship with my husband became very bad after giving birth. I even had a kind of physical disgust towards him and felt extremely annoyed. When I saw other mothers on Xiaohongshu complaining about their husbands, I could strongly relate to what they were saying.”

Her experience suggests that support is not created solely through practical information, but also through emotional resonance with other mothers’ experiences shared on Xiaohongshu. Also, such content creates a sense of normalisation, which may make her feel that her feelings towards her husband were not isolated but are shared in the motherhood community. This aligns with previous research, which argues that belonging is closely associated with feeling understood and recognised within a social context (Correll and Park, 2005).

Another participant expressed a similar feeling, further highlighting the differences between online and offline interactions during the transition to motherhood. She explained:

“I’m sometimes afraid of bothering my friends, and I also worry about embarrassing myself in front of people I know. Talking too much with acquaintances can feel burdensome. But online, when I see another version of myself in the world - someone having the same experiences - it gives me this immediate sense of familiarity.”

This participant described feeling hesitant to share her experiences with people she knows, as it could make her feel judged or a burden. In contrast, Xiaohongshu enabled her to find others who are going through similar stages, making it easier to express her thoughts and emotions

without these constraints. This suggests that a sense of belonging to motherhood on Xiaohongshu is easier to achieve because of social pressure in offline relationships.

Their feelings of being understood and recognised by others within a shared identity group reflect what Hoffmann and Ignatieff (1994) describe as a core element of belonging. It also supports Baumeister and Leary's (1995) argument that a sense of belonging emerges when individuals feel accepted and emotionally connected within a meaningful social context. Moreover, this finding suggests that participants may rely more on platform-based communities to negotiate their identity during early motherhood, particularly when offline environments are perceived as less comfortable for expressing personal or sensitive experiences. Importantly, this sense of belonging is shaped through algorithmic recommendation processes. By repeatedly presenting similar content and prioritising certain topics through visibility ranking, the recommendation system ensures that relatable narratives are presented in users' feeds (Vombatkere et al., 2024). Thus, algorithmic recommendation does not simply provide access to shared experiences but actively structures how often and how prominently these contents appear, thereby reinforcing where and how new mothers feel a sense of belonging.

4.2.2 Exclusion – Comparison and Stigma

Although participants felt a sense of belonging mainly through helpful information and emotional support, they also experienced exclusion from the same motherhood content. Based on participants' explanations, exclusion in this study can be understood in two forms: comparison pressure and stigma associated with Xiaohongshu's mother community.

Most participants acknowledged that they experienced anxiety, and in some cases jealousy, when repeatedly exposed to motherhood-related posts. This pressure was most commonly described in relation to comparison with other mothers, particularly those presented as

idealised or “perfect” figures online. For example, several participants reported feeling unable to meet the standards portrayed in these posts, such as always being patient with their children, successfully balancing work and family life, or quickly returning to their pre-pregnancy body shape. The representations participants are exposed to can be understood as normative templates of motherhood, reflecting broader ideals of “good mother ideology” and “intensive mothering” (Simon and Landis, 1989; O'Reilly, 2010).

While comparison is a common social process in everyday life (Festinger, 1954), participants suggested that this experience was intensified on Xiaohongshu. On Xiaohongshu, such templates are not encountered randomly but are selectively amplified through the recommendation system, which prioritises content that is more engaging, visually appealing, or performative (Zhang, Chen and Xi, 2020). As a result, highly curated and “highlight” moments are more likely to be repeatedly presented, while more ordinary experiences related to motherhood remain underrepresented. These idealised portrayals may serve as benchmarks for new mothers to compare themselves against. This indicates that algorithmically curated content may amplify upward social comparison by repeatedly exposing users to highly selective and idealised representations. As a result, these comparisons began to shape participants’ self-perceptions, with several reporting a sense of inadequacy in their roles as mothers. This aligns with existing research suggesting that exposure to idealised content on social media can negatively affect self-esteem and self-evaluation (Lee, 2014).

One participant provided a particularly insightful reflection on this phenomenon:

“There’s also a type of mum who seems very anxious, and they use posts to prove themselves. For example, they show that right after giving birth, they dropped to a really low weight, or that their two-year-old kid can already recite loads of ancient poems because of early

education. Xiaohongshu becomes a platform for proving yourself, and at the same time, it makes mothers even more anxious.”

This participant recognised that some posts were performative, aiming to demonstrate competence or success in motherhood. In this example, “performative” refers to the tendency for users to present measurable or visible achievements, such as a child’s early development or post-pregnancy recovery, to demonstrate their capability as mothers. As Xiaohongshu encourages creators to produce attention-grabbing posts (Zhang, Chen and Xi, 2020), the more engagement such posts have, such as likes, comments, and sharing, the more desirable they will be for mothers to become. This reflects Freitas’s (2017) argument that social media can reshape perceptions of what is considered “normal,” often in distorted or unrealistic ways.

However, not all participants experienced this pressure equally. One participant stated that she did not feel anxious when exposed to such content. She attributed this to her understanding of how social media platforms operate, including how creators design content to attract attention and maximise engagement. With a background in psychology and prior experience in content creation, she interpreted “perfect motherhood” posts as strategic performances rather than realistic representations.

This case highlights an important variation in participants’ responses, suggesting that the effects of algorithmically recommended content are not uniform, but are mediated by users’ own interpretive frameworks. Her interpretation of Xiaohongshu content led to a different emotional outcome. This suggests that mothers with greater platform awareness may reduce the intensity of comparisons and associated feelings of pressure and exclusion from the motherhood community.

Besides the pressure from comparison, some participants also described a stronger sense of exclusion within the platform environment itself. This exclusion did not always come directly from motherhood content, but from the negative discourse and bias they perceived around the identity of being a mother on Xiaohongshu.

One participant mentioned that there is a visible prejudice against “*bao ma*” on the platform, which means babies’ mothers in literal terms. She explained that “*bao ma*” are often stereotyped as people who constantly post pictures of their children and have an unrealistic “filter” for children’s appearances. She referred to a trend on Xiaohongshu in which mothers post their children under the title “*Is my child suitable to be a child model?*”, which often attracts critical or mocking responses from other users. The comments are usually sarcastic or humorous, implicitly questioning both the child’s appearance, which is deemed unsuitable for a model, and the mother’s judgment.

Due to this phenomenon, the participant chose not to post her child, as she anticipated that such content might be judged negatively or perceived as overly confident. This anticipatory dynamic can be understood as a form of self-censorship, where users adjust their behaviour in response to perceived audience norms and potential criticism. Therefore, the participant limited her self-presentation on Xiaohongshu to avoid negative evaluation. This finding aligns with Williams’ (2007) work on ostracism, which suggests that even the anticipation of rejection can threaten individuals’ sense of belonging and prompt behavioural adjustment. Similarly, Marwick and boyd (2011) argue that in social media environments characterised by context collapse, users often engage in self-censorship as a strategy to avoid judgment.

To conclude, new mothers can experience exclusion on Xiaohongshu through feeling inferior to other mothers during comparisons and through negative platform discourse about

motherhood, where users modify their behaviour based on how they anticipate their identity as mothers will be judged.

4.3 Identity Negotiation and Adaptation

(RQ3: How do participants experience career-motherhood identity tensions within algorithmically curated content, and how do they respond to these tensions?)

4.3.1 Tensions

Based on their interaction with Xiaohongshu, participants experienced tensions between their career and motherhood identities in two ways: (1) comparisons with mothers who appeared to successfully balance work and childcare, and (2) the platform's broader discourse that positions working mothers and stay-at-home mothers in opposition to each other.

Among the seven participants, three became stay-at-home mothers after having children, while two switched to more flexible jobs instead of their office roles. Only two of them are still pursuing the same job as before. Most working mothers noticed that they frequently see examples who have returned to work after maternity leave on Xiaohongshu, often presented as capable and productive in both work and home. One of them expressed:

“On Xiaohongshu, I see many working mums. They’re like elite professionals who manage to balance childcare and work really well. They don’t seem to have much emotional stress, and they don’t seem disconnected from their careers either... I genuinely admire them... but at the same time, I also feel this deep sense of powerlessness... like I just can’t compare at all. And sometimes, I even feel a bit ashamed of myself.”

Her experience suggests that the tension is shaped by comparisons between herself and mothers who have returned to work but have demonstrated outstanding performance in

managing two identities simultaneously. Although many studies have demonstrated motherhood transition can lead to new mothers' dual pressure from both work and family (Okorn et al., 2025), the repeated exposed content on Xiaohongshu amplifies this pressure by sending the "perfect" working mother images to users.

Moreover, the comparisons led the participant to deepen their discomfort with identity, including feelings of inferiority and an inability to achieve the working-mother image on Xiaohongshu. This also resulted in negative emotions, which she described as hopelessness and shame, which is consistent with Roccas and Brewer's (2002) research on the emotional effects caused by conflicting identities.

In addition to comparison-based tension, participants also experienced identity conflict through the platform's discursive environment. Several participants noted that Xiaohongshu tends to position working mothers and stay-at-home mothers as identities in contest. As one stay-at-home mother explained:

"On Xiaohongshu, I feel like there's a general trend of rejecting the idea of women staying at home to 'support the family and raise children'... This idea is seen as completely negative, almost like it's something unacceptable"

Her observation suggests that the platform does not present different motherhood choices neutrally but amplifies particular normative expectations through repeated exposure to content. Working mothers are often framed as independent and capable, while stay-at-home mothers may be positioned as lacking self-development. This pattern can be explained by the increasing visibility of feminist discourse in China, particularly on platforms such as Xiaohongshu. As some studies suggest, some feminists in China value the "independent woman" ideal, while devaluing alternative choices such as voluntary stay-at-home motherhood (Geng et al., 2024). In this case, Xiaohongshu influences identity negotiation

between careers and motherhood by structuring what appears to be a better choice, which is expected through repeated exposure, making a particular identity or choice appear more desirable than others.

This participant also developed a critical awareness of the platform's discourse. She recognised that such representations reflect a biased understanding of women's roles, rather than an objective reality:

“But personally, I think this way of understanding women is quite biased. Ideally, women should be respected by society regardless of whether they choose to pursue a career or stay at home to take care of their children.”

This critical perspective influenced how she interacted with the platform environment, leading her to actively engage with it and challenge the prevailing discourse, demonstrating her commitment to thoughtful discussion.

4.3.2 Responses

When facing these identity conflicts, participants adopted both active and passive behaviours. The stay-at-home mother who provided an insightful opinion above chose to directly respond to posts that criticised stay-at-home mothers, either by commenting or sending private messages to express her disagreement. She also used platform features such as selecting “not interested” to actively filter out content she was uncomfortable with. These behaviours can be seen as deliberate efforts to influence the recommendation system, demonstrating user agency in challenging dominant narratives related to the identity conflict.

Another participant also used an active method, but in a different way. She described how, once she opened Xiaohongshu, “*everything is about babies*,” which made her realise that career identity had become less visible there. Before pregnancy, she placed great value on her

profession and identity. However, the platform environment made her feel *“being continuously pulled my attention back to only kids.”*

The limited space in the recommendation feed is increasingly dominated by motherhood content, reducing the visibility of other identity-related content. Over time, this may narrow users’ exposure and reshape their sense of self. In response, she deliberately adopted strategies to regain control over her attention, such as

“Switching to a different account”, or “using my mum’s phone to watch some funny videos and keep myself away from childcare content.”

Her strategies can be understood as forms of attention recapture and self-repair, as she actively seeks to reintroduce aspects of her identity that have become less visible. This self-management approach helped her gain a more balanced sense of self.

However, not all participants adopted such active strategies. Some engaged in more passive forms of adaptation. They described simply ignoring unwanted content, avoiding clicking on certain posts, or quickly exiting content they did not want to engage with. These adaptations reflect a more subtle coping strategy, in which users do not attempt to change the recommendation system but instead adjust their engagement patterns to minimise discomfort.

5. Conclusion

5.1 Summary of the Study

This dissertation examined how algorithmically recommended content on Xiaohongshu is interpreted and experienced by new mothers during the transition from career roles to motherhood. In the context of personalised social media feeds, users are increasingly exposed to content based on their browsing, searching, and engagement behaviours. For new mothers,

this process is particularly significant, as the transition to motherhood often involves changes in identity, emotional needs, social expectations, everyday priorities, and so on.

Existing research has discussed digital identity, platform algorithms, and online motherhood separately. However, less attention has been paid to how new mothers themselves interpret recommended content during identity transition, and how this relates to their sense of belonging, exclusion, and career-motherhood tension.

5.2 Summary of Findings

Overall, the findings suggest that algorithmically recommended content not only provides information for new mothers but also becomes a way through which participants understand their changing identities, evaluate themselves in relation to others, and negotiate tensions between motherhood and career roles.

For RQ1, the findings show that participants developed incomplete but meaningful interpretations of Xiaohongshu's recommendation system through everyday platform use. Their explanations can be divided into three main types of algorithmic imaginaries. The first is behaviour-driven algorithmic imaginary, where participants believed that the platform recommends content based on their actions, such as clicking, watching, and searching. The second is engagement-based algorithmic imaginary, where participants referred to likes, saved posts, and video completion rates as signals that may influence what content appears in their feeds. The third is a broader data-driven algorithmic imaginary, where some participants explained recommendation through "big data" and the collection of user behavioural data.

These interpretations also shaped how participants understood the relationship between recommended content and digital identity. Many participants connected the changes in their feed to their changing priorities during pregnancy and early motherhood. For example, some

described no longer actively searching for fashion or beauty content, which they had enjoyed before the transition, and instead searching more frequently for pregnancy, childcare, or baby-related information. In this sense, recommended content was interpreted as a form of feedback, where the platform appeared to recognise them as mothers and continuously reflect this identity back to them.

For RQ2, the findings show that participants experienced both online belonging and exclusion through repeated exposure to motherhood-related content. Belonging was mainly produced through informational and emotional support. Repeated exposure to parenting advice, childcare knowledge, and other mothers' shared experiences helped participants reduce uncertainty and feel less isolated during early motherhood. This form of belonging was not always based on direct interaction with other users. Instead, it was often created through the repeated presence of relevant and recognisable content in the recommendation feed, which made participants feel seen and understood within the motherhood community. This suggests that belonging on Xiaohongshu can be driven by content and mediated algorithmically.

However, the same motherhood-related content also produced exclusion. Participants described pressure when they were repeatedly exposed to idealised images of "perfect" mothers, such as mothers who balanced work and childcare well, recovered their bodies quickly after childbirth, or appeared highly patient and emotionally stable. These images became comparison standards, leading some participants to feel inadequate, powerless, or ashamed. However, this pressure was not experienced equally by all participants. One participant did not feel negatively affected by these idealised portrayals because she had prior knowledge of content creation and understood that creators often design posts to attract attention and increase engagement. She therefore interpreted "perfect mother" content as a

form of performance rather than reality. This suggests that the emotional impact of algorithmically curated content may depend on users' interpretations of online images and their level of platform awareness. In addition, some participants felt excluded by negative platform discourse around "bao ma", where mothers were sometimes stereotyped as annoying, overly confident, or overly focused on their children. Therefore, exclusion was not only caused by a lack of support, but also by comparison, stigma, and the anticipation of being judged.

For RQ3, the findings show that participants experienced tensions between career and motherhood identities in relation to Xiaohongshu's recommended content. For some participants, career identity became less present in their feeds, while motherhood-related content became increasingly dominant. This created a sense of displacement, where participants felt pulled towards the mother identity even when they still valued their career, previous interests, or other aspects of the self. Some participants also noticed that Xiaohongshu discourse often placed working mothers and stay-at-home mothers in opposition to each other. This created further tension, as both choices could be judged through different moral expectations.

Participants responded to these tensions in different ways. Some adopted active strategies, such as selecting "not interested", commenting under posts, sending private messages, or using alternative accounts to change their feed. Others adopted more passive strategies, such as ignoring unwanted content, avoiding certain posts, or quickly exiting content they did not want to engage with. These responses show that participants were not simply passive users of algorithmic recommendation. Instead, they actively negotiated, resisted, or adapted to the platform environment in everyday ways.

5.3 Evaluation of the Study

5.3.1 Strengths of the Study

One strength of this study is its user-centred and interpretivist approach. Instead of treating algorithmic recommendation as a technical system to be measured, this research takes mothers' subjective interpretation, daily experience and emotional perception as the core entry point. This approach is highly consistent with the research theme of identity transition, emotional experience and subjective meaning construction, and provides a limited research perspective for the interdisciplinary study of platform algorithms and motherhood identity transition.

Second, this study reveals the dual attributes of algorithmic content (support vs. pressure). This finding confirms that algorithmic platforms are a double-edged sword for new mothers' identity transition and points out the negative emotional effect may be moderated by platform awareness and media literacy.

5.3.2 Limitation of the Study

However, this study also has limitations. First, the sample size and representativeness are limited, which restricts the generalisability of the findings. This study adopts a qualitative research design and selects 7 participants. Although in-depth qualitative data is obtained through semi-structured interviews, the small sample size cannot cover new mothers with diverse demographic characteristics, such as mothers in different age groups, mothers with different family economic status, and mothers with multiple children. Also, participants are from different tier cities in China, with differences in regional economic development, childcare resource allocation, employment policies and so on. This study does not take contextual variables as core analysis dimensions, resulting in insufficient exploration of how

regional and family contexts interact with algorithmic content to shape maternal identity experience.

In addition, there is a potential self-selection bias in sample recruitment. All participants were recruited through Xiaohongshu platform, which means the participants may have high willingness to express and share their experiences. Users who have negative platform experiences or are unwilling to discuss maternal and platform use issues are excluded from the sample. This recruitment bias may lead to the overestimation of new mothers' active coping strategies towards algorithmic content to a certain extent, affecting the findings.

5.3.3 Directions for Future Research

Based on the above limitations, future research can be expanded and improved from three aspects. First, expand the sample diversity and scale to enhance the generalisability of findings. Future studies can select new mothers from different tier cities, employment backgrounds, family structures, age groups and fertility experiences as research objects, combine qualitative and quantitative research methods, and explore the differences and influencing mechanisms of algorithmic content perception among heterogeneous maternal groups, so as to obtain more universal research conclusions.

Moreover, the research can adopt cross-platform comparative research to explore the platform specificity of maternal identity experience. For example, it can select different social media platforms (such as Douyin, WeChat groups, Zhihu, and parenting vertical platforms) as comparative cases. It can help analyse the differences in algorithmic recommendation logic and discourse norms between platforms, to explore how different platform environments shape users' sense of belonging, exclusion and identity negotiation. This can further verify the universality and specificity of the relationship between platform algorithms and maternal identity.

5.4 Overall Conclusion

Overall, this dissertation has shown that algorithmically recommended content on Xiaohongshu plays an important role in how new mothers understand themselves during the identity transition from a career-dominant role. It provides support and connection, but also creates comparison, pressure, and exclusion. By focusing on users' interpretations, this study highlights the importance of understanding digital identity not only as self-presentation, but also as platform-positioning within algorithmically curated environments.

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AI Declaration

I declare that part of this submission has contributions from AI software and that it aligns with acceptable use as specified as part of the assignment brief/guidance and is consistent with good academic practice. The content can still be considered as my own words.

I understand that as long as my use falls within the scope of appropriate use as defined in the assessment brief/guidance then this declaration will not have any direct impact on the grades awarded.

I acknowledge use of software to

- (i) Generate ideas or structure suggestions, for assistance with understanding core concepts, or other substantial foundational and preparatory activity. *[ChatGPT]*
- (ii) Write, rewrite, rephrase and/or paraphrase part of this essay. *[ChatGPT]*

7. Appendix

(As the research was conducted in Chinese, the documents, such as recruitment posts, screening questions, and initial coding, are translated into English in the Appendix.)

A. Minimal Risk Ethical Clearance

Research Ethics Office

3rd Floor
6-8 Lavender Street
London WC2E 7LQ
info@kcl.ac.uk



03/03/2026

Yihan Yang

Dear Yihan

How browsing behaviour and algorithmic recommendations on Xiaohongshu shape women's perceptions of identity during the transition from career to motherhood

Thank you for submitting your Minimal Risk Self Registration Form. This letter acknowledges confirmation of your registration; your registration confirmation reference number is MRSU-25/26-54656

Ethical Clearance

Ethical clearance is granted for a period of **one year** from today's date and you may now commence data collection. However, it is important that you have read through the information provided below before commencing data collection:

As the Minimal Risk Registration Process is based on self-registration, your form has not been reviewed by the College Research Ethics Committee. It is therefore your responsibility to ensure that your project adheres to the [Minimal Risk Guiding Principles](#) and the agreed protocol does not fall outside of the criteria for Minimal Risk Registration.

Record Keeping:

Please be sure to keep a record of your registration number and include it in any materials associated with this research. It is the responsibility of the researcher to ensure that any other permissions or approvals (i.e. R&D, gatekeepers, etc.) relevant to their research are in place, prior to conducting the research.

In addition, you are expected to keep records of your process of informed consent and the dates and relevant details of research covered by this application. For example, depending on the type of research that you are doing, you might keep:

- A record of all data collected and all mechanisms of disseminated results.
- Documentation of your informed consent process. This may include written information sheets or in cases where it is not appropriate to provide written information, the verbal script or introductory material provided at the start of an online survey.

Please note: For projects involving the use of an Information Sheet and Consent Form for recruitment purposes, please ensure that you use the [KCL GDPR compliant Information Sheet & Consent Form Templates](#)

- Where appropriate, records of consent, e.g. copies of signed consent forms or emails where participants agree to be interviewed.

Audit:

You may be selected for an audit, to see how researchers are implementing this process. If audited, you and your Supervisor will be asked to attend a short meeting where you will be expected to explain how your research meets the eligibility criteria of the minimal risk process and how the project abides by the general principles of ethical research. In particular, you will be expected to provide a general summary of your review of the possible risks involved in your research, as well as to provide basic research records (as above in Record Keeping) and to describe the process by which participants agreed to participate in your research.

Remember that if you at any point have any questions about the ethical conduct of your research, or believe you may have gained the incorrect level of ethical clearance, please contact your supervisor or the Research Ethics Office.

Data Protection Registration

If you indicated in your minimal risk registration form that personal data would be processed as part of this research project, this letter also confirms that you have also met your requirements for registering this processing activity with King's College London in accordance with the UK General Data Protection Regulation (UK GDPR). Please note that any changes to the storage, management, or type of personal data being collected should also be included in a modification request. More information about how the UK GDPR affects researchers can be found [here](#).

We wish you every success with your project moving forward.

With best wishes,

The Research Ethics Office
On behalf of the College Research Ethics Committee

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B. Consent Form

CONSENT FORM FOR PARTICIPANTS IN RESEARCH PROJECTS

Please complete this form after you have read the Information Sheet and/or listened to an explanation about the research.



Title of project: Algorithmic Recommendation and Women's Identity Transition from Career to Motherhood: A Case Study of Xiaohongshu.	
Ethical review reference number: MRSU-25/26-54656	Version number: 13/03/2026
1. I confirm that I have read and understood the information sheet dated 13/03/2026 for the above project and that I meet the eligibility criteria. I confirm I have had the opportunity to consider the information provided and to ask questions which have been answered to my satisfaction.	
2. I consent voluntarily to be a participant in this project and understand that I can refuse to take part and can withdraw from the project at any time, without having to give a reason, up until April 1 st 2026, after which withdrawal of my data will no longer be possible due to the data will have been anonymised and incorporated into the research analysis.	
3. I understand my personal information will be processed for the purposes explained to me in the Information Sheet. I understand that such information will be handled under the terms of UK data protection law, including the UK GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018.	
4. I understand that my information may be subject to review by responsible individuals from the College for monitoring and audit purposes.	
5. I understand that my identity will remain anonymous in all research outputs, as explained in the Information Sheet.	
6. I consent to my anonymised data being shared with third parties transcription service used for this research.	
7. I understand that my anonymised data will only be used for the purposes of this dissertation.	

_____ Name of Participant	_____ Date	_____ Signature
_____ Name of Researcher	_____ Date	_____ Signature

C. Information Sheet

Version Number 13/03/2026

INFORMATION SHEET FOR PARTICIPANTS

Ethical Clearance Reference Number: [MRSU-25/26-54656]



YOU WILL BE GIVEN A COPY OF THIS INFORMATION SHEET

Title of project

Algorithmic Recommendation and Women's Identity Transition from Career to Motherhood: A Case Study of Xiaohongshu

Invitation Paragraph

I would like to invite you to participate in this research project which forms part of my Undergraduate Dissertation research. Before you decide whether you want to take part, it is important for you to understand why the research is being done and what your participation will involve. Please take time to read the following information carefully and discuss it with others if you wish. Ask me if there is anything that is not clear or if you would like more information.

What is the purpose of the project?

The purpose of the project is to explore how algorithmically recommended content on Xiaohongshu may influence women's experiences of identity and belonging during early motherhood. It may include their feelings of belonging, exclusion, and pressure when interpreting the content recommended by Xiaohongshu.

Why have I been invited to take part?

You are being invited to participate in this project because you meet the criteria for this study. Participants in this research are:

- Women who are active Xiaohongshu users for at least three years.
- Women who have become mothers within the past three years.
- Participants must be over 18 years old.

Your experience using Xiaohongshu during early motherhood may help provide valuable insights for this research.

What will happen if I take part?

If you choose to take part in the project you will be asked to attend an online interview lasting approximately 30-40 minutes.

During the interview, you will be asked questions about:

- Your experiences using Xiaohongshu
- The types of content recommended to you before, during and after the identity transition
- Whether you have noticed changes in the content you see after becoming a mother
- Your feelings about motherhood-related/ career-related content on the platform

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Participation will take place through WeChat voice call or Tencent Meeting, depending on your preference. As part of participation, you will be asked to provide your true experiences related to the interview questions. With your permission, the interview may be audio-recorded to support accurate transcription and analysis. If you prefer not to be recorded, the researcher will take detailed notes instead.

Do I have to take part?

Participation is completely voluntary. You should only take part if you want to and choosing not to take part will not disadvantage you in any way. Once you have read the information sheet, please contact us if you have any questions that will help you make a decision about taking part. If you decide to take part, we will ask you to sign a consent form and will give you a copy of this to keep.

Incentives

As a small token of appreciation for your time, participants may receive a small thank-you payment after completing the interview.

What are the possible risks of taking part?

This study does not involve any significant risks. However, you are free to skip any question you do not wish to answer.

What are the possible benefits of taking part?

There are no direct personal benefits to participating in this study.

However, your participation may help contribute understanding of how social media platforms influence users' experiences during important life transitions.

Data handling and confidentiality

I will need to use information from you (e.g., age, motherhood status, job status) for this research project.

Your name and personal identity will not be included in the research outputs. All data will be anonymised.

Interview recordings and transcripts will be stored securely and only accessed by the researcher for the purpose of this study.

The research team and authorised administrative staff will use this information to do the research or to check your records to make sure that the research is being done properly.

Your data will be processed in compliance with UK data protection laws, including the UK GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018.

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Further information on how King's processes research data can be found at:

<https://www.kcl.ac.uk/research/support/research-ethics/kings-college-london-statement-on-use-of-personal-data-in-research>

Please contact the research team if you require further information on data processing or a printed version of the webpage link above.

What if I change my mind about taking part?

You are free to withdraw at any point of the project, without having to give a reason. Withdrawing from the project will not affect you in any way. You are able to withdraw your data from the project up until April 1st, 2026, after which withdrawal of your data will no longer be possible due to the data will have been anonymised and incorporated into the research analysis.

If you choose to withdraw from the project, we will retain the minimum amount of data required to manage our records and complete the research project.

How is the project being funded?

This project is self-funded.

What will happen to the results of the project?

The results of the project will be summarised in undergraduate dissertation submitted to King's College London. The findings may also be used in academic presentations or publications in the future, but all data will remain fully anonymised.

Who should I contact for further information?

If you have any questions or require more information about this project, please contact me using the following contact details:

Researcher: Yihan Yang
Email: k23029070@kcl.ac.uk

What if I have further questions, or if something goes wrong?

If this project has harmed you in any way, or if you wish to make a complaint about the conduct of the project you can contact King's College London using the details below for further advice and information:

Supervisor: Dr. Karishma Banga
Email: karishma.banga@kcl.ac.uk

Thank you for reading this information sheet and for considering taking part in this research.

3

D. Recruitment Post & Screening Questions

From Career Woman to Mother: A Period of Identity Transition

Hello, I am an undergraduate student majoring in Digital Media and currently working on my graduation thesis. I hope to understand everyone's user experience on rednote.

This research primarily focuses on one question:
How do new mothers interpret the content recommended by the algorithm on rednote as a reflection of their digital identity? And how does this interpretation relate to their online experiences?

I hope to understand everyone's authentic experiences on rednote through interviews.

I am currently recruiting 5-7 participants willing to be interviewed online. The interview will last approximately 30-40 minutes and will be conducted via WeChat Voice or Tencent Meeting.

Participant Criteria:

1. Female, rednote user
2. Used rednote for at least 3 years
3. Became a mother within the last 3 years
4. Aged 18 or older

The interview will mainly be a chat about how you usually use rednote, and whether this recommended content affects your feelings about your identity, sense of belonging, or stress. There are no right or wrong answers.

Privacy Notice:

The interview is completely voluntary.

All information will be anonymized.

It will be used for academic purposes only.

Recordings and transcripts will be deleted after the thesis is graded.

If you are interested in participating or would like more information, please send me a private message.

Hi! In order to confirm whether you are eligible to participate in this study, I'd like to first ask you a few basic questions. If convenient, please feel free to answer the following:



- 1 Your name or nickname (for contact purposes only; your identity will be kept anonymous in the study):
- 2 Your child's current age:
- 3 How many years have you been using Xiaohongshu (Little Red Book):
- 4 Since becoming a mother, have you noticed any changes in the types of content recommended to you on Xiaohongshu? For example, more content related to motherhood, parenting, or child development, or less content related to work or career.
- 5 Are you willing to share how you feel or experience the recommended content during the interview? For instance, some people may find that the recommended content becomes more focused on parenting topics, which might strengthen a sense of "belonging to the motherhood community." Others may feel that such content brings pressure, or that they are still seen primarily as "working women" on the platform. Of course, if your experience or these examples do not apply to you, that's completely fine.

This information is only used to confirm whether participants match the research topic. All information will be kept anonymous in the study.

E. Semi-structured Interview Questions

Interview Questions

Background Questions

1. Could you briefly tell me about your background?
 - How old is your child?
 - What is your current work status?
 - Which city do you currently live or work in?
 - How long have you been using Xiaohongshu?
 - How do you usually use Xiaohongshu?

RQ1: Participants' Understanding of Recommendation and Content Change

2. After becoming a mother, have you noticed any changes in the content Xiaohongshu recommends to you?

Possible follow-up questions:

- When did you first notice this change?
- What kinds of content became more common in your feed?
- Were there any types of content you used to see more often, but now see less frequently?
- 3. How do you understand why Xiaohongshu recommends this kind of content to you?

Possible follow-up questions:

- What kind of user do you think the platform sees you as?
- Have there been times when the recommendations did not match your actual interests or situation?

RQ2: Belonging, Support, Pressure, and Exclusion

4. When you often see motherhood-related content on Xiaohongshu, how does it make you feel?

Possible follow-up questions:

- Does it ever make you feel more connected to other mothers or motherhood-related communities?
- Is this feeling different from what you experience in offline life?

5. Have there been moments when motherhood-related content on Xiaohongshu made you feel pressure or discomfort?

Possible follow-up questions:

- What kind of pressure did you experience, if any? For example, comparison, anxiety, self-doubt, or something else?
- Can you think of any specific posts or types of content that left a strong impression on you?
- Is this feeling stronger on Xiaohongshu, or does it also appear in offline life?

RQ3: Career–Motherhood Identity Tensions and Responses

6. When Xiaohongshu recommends more motherhood-related content to you, how do you feel about the way the platform understands you as a user?

Possible follow-up questions:

- Do you feel that Xiaohongshu sees you more as a "mother user"?
- Does this feel natural to you, or does it feel unexpected?
- 7. Compared with before, do you feel that your career identity or previous interests have become less visible on Xiaohongshu?

Possible follow-up questions:

- Do you think this is more because your own interests have changed, or because the platform recommends more motherhood-related content?
- How do you feel when content you used to follow appears less often?
- Do you feel Xiaohongshu's recommended content influences this balance in any way?

9. When the content recommended by Xiaohongshu does not match your current feelings, interests, or identity, how do you usually respond?

Closing Question

Overall, do you feel Xiaohongshu's recommended content has been more helpful or more pressuring for how you understand yourself after becoming a mother? Why?

Possible follow-up questions:

- In what ways has it been helpful?
- In what ways has it created pressure?
- Where do you think this support or pressure mainly comes from?

F. Coding Frames

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G
Child's age	3yo	2.5yo	3yo	2y3m	2y8m	8m	1.5yo
Years using XHS	4 years	4.5 years	4.5 years	10 years	4.5 years	5.6 years	4.5 years
Work status	Office worker -> full-time mother	Office worker -> full-time mother	Office worker -> flexible work	Office worker	Office worker -> full-time mother	Office worker	Office worker -> flexible work
City	Shenzhen	Tai'an	Hangzhou	Harbin	Shenyang	Harbin	Tai'an
Previous content	Beauty Fashion Product recommendations	Nail care Fashion Drinks	Beauty Hobbies Product recommendations	Beauty Hobbies	Beauty Fashion	Beauty Fashion Food	Fashion Travel guides
Current content	From pregnancy preparation Early education Finding tutors Recruitment	From pregnancy Early education Toys Complementary food	From pregnancy Early education Balancing childcare	From pregnancy preparation Early education Baby care Complementary food	From pregnancy Baby products Complementary food Only watches previously followed fashion accounts; no longer searches	From pregnancy Complementary food Uses XHS like Google	From pregnancy Interest development
Support	Organising experiences	Organising experiences	Organising experiences	Organising experiences	Organising experiences	Organising experiences	Organising experiences
Pressure	None Psychology background and previous content-creation experience; sees 'perfect mother' images on XHS as attention-grabbing	Yes 'Envy': others take children out and are patient Online pressure is more obvious Offline peers are closer in economic level and parenting style	Yes Content distortion / distrust Impression that 'everyone on Xiaohongshu earns a million a year' Admiration for mothers who balance family	Yes Comparison and inner conflict Cannot do things that well	Yes Content distortion / distrust Comparison and anxiety: others make money online through their babies Economic pressure Also knows people beautify themselves	Yes Comparison: body recovery	Yes Comparison: patience, cooking Also knows people beautify themselves online
Algorithm	The algorithm recommends what you watch	It recommends what you watch; designed to keep users engaged	It recommends what you watch; responds to needs Completion rate Likes and saves	What you watch is what gets recommended	The algorithm recommends what you watch	Big data Recommendation mechanism	The algorithm recommends what you watch
Resisting the algorithm	Ignores content Feels disgusted / taps not interested	Ignores content	Ignores content Actively looks for more authentic content Taps 'Not interested' Uses different devices	Ignores content	Ignores content	Ignores content	Ignores content Quickly swipes past
Motherhood community inclusion	Resonance: Physical aversion to husband Feels inequality and personal suffering	Informational help: Complementary food	Resonance	Informational help: Complementary food	Informational help: Complementary food	Resonance: Changed views on breastfeeding Offline: older relatives' advice feels dismissive	Informational help: Child illness
Identity loss / exclusion	Accepts it	Sense of loss Loss of other identities: 'someone's mum'	Loss of self-worth Loss of other identities Once she opens XHS, it is all babies Tries to focus more on herself	Accepts it	Sense of loss Thinks she should focus more on herself	Accepts it But notes prejudice against mothers on XHS: always posting children, filtered view, overconfidence So she does not post and is afraid of annoying others	Loss of other identities: 'someone's mum'
Compared with reality	Online is more helpful But also more pressure	Online is more helpful But also more pressure	Online is more helpful Offline: afraid of being laughed at But also more pressure	Online is more helpful But also more pressure	Offline creates more resonance	Online is more helpful	Offline friends understand her better

Research Question	Main Theme	Sub-themes	Examples from Initial Coding
RQ1	Identity Transition and Perceptions of Algorithmic Recommendation	- Content shift during motherhood transition - Behaviour-driven recommendation - Engagement-driven recommendation - Big data recommendation	- Feed changed from beauty, fashion, food, travel, or hobbies to early education, baby food, baby products, and childcare advice - Several participants noticed this change from pregnancy or preparing for pregnancy "See what you watch, then recommend similar content" - Recommendations linked to clicks, searches, likes, saves, and completion rate - Some participants described Xiaohongshu as driven by "big data"
RQ2	Belonging and Exclusion	- Informational support - Emotional resonance - Comparison pressure - Stigma and self-censorship	- Useful support through content on complementary food, baby illness, breastfeeding, toys, and childcare experience - Feeling understood through shared experiences with other mothers - Pressure from idealised mothers: patience, body recovery, balancing work and childcare, making money through parenting content - Some participants recognised content as filtered, exaggerated, or ad-like - Perceived prejudice against "bao ma" on Xiaohongshu led one participant to avoid posting about her child
RQ3	Identity Negotiation and Passive Adaptation	- Reduced visibility of previous identity - Career-motherhood tension - Active resistance - Passive adaptation	- Some participants felt they had become only a "mother user" on Xiaohongshu - Career or previous interests became less visible in the feed - Tensions between office worker and stay-at-home mother identities - Active responses: searching for more "real" content, selecting "not interested", using different devices or accounts, commenting or messaging to express disagreement - Passive responses: ignoring content, quickly scrolling away, or avoiding certain posts